

Caecilians

Order Gymnophiona

Ringed caecilian

Siphonops annulatus

- ↔ 8–16 in (20–40 cm)
- 📍 N. South America
- ⊗ Common

Like all caecilians, this legless, burrowing amphibian preys on small invertebrates. Unusually for amphibians, caecilians reproduce by internal fertilization, with the male and female physically mating together. The female lays her eggs in the soil. The newly hatched infants are nourished by grazing on the outer layers of the mother's skin.



Common spadefoot toad

Pelobates fuscus

- ↔ 2–3 in (5–7.6 cm)
- 📍 C. and E. Europe, W. Asia
- ⊗ Common

Spadefoot toads are so-called because their feet have a horny lump for pushing soil as they burrow backward into the ground. This common European species is also known as the “garlic toad” because of its distinctive odorous secretion, which may serve to repel predators. Like other spadefoot toads, this amphibian is most active above ground during rains, when it lays its eggs in ponds.

Frogs and toads

Order Anura

Oriental fire-bellied toad

Bombina orientalis

- ↔ 1–2 in (2.5–5 cm)
- 📍 E and SE. Asia
- ⊗ Locally common

This small, vivid green toad of wet Asian forests uses color to startle predators and warn them of its skin's toxicity—just like several other species of fire-bellied toads. Its belly is bright red with black spots. When attacked, the toad flashes the pattern by flattening its body,

lifting its legs, and sometimes even rolling onto its back. The male calls to attract a mate. The female lays eggs under rocks in streams.

rounded warts on back



Surinam toad

Pipa pipa

- ↔ 2–8 in (5–20 cm)
- 📍 N. South America
- ⊗ Common

This entirely aquatic toad has remarkable breeding habits. A mating pair does somersaults in the water, and fertilized eggs attach to the back of the female—where they develop in honeycomb-like pockets. The eggs hatch into miniature toads; in related species, they release filter-feeding tadpoles.

Mexican burrowing toad

Rhinophrynus dorsalis

- ↔ 2–3 in (5–7.6 cm)
- 📍 S. US to Central America
- ⊗ Common

This small-headed toad—the sole species in its family—has large feet for digging burrows. It feeds on underground insects, uniquely catching them by projecting its tongue through a gap at the front

of its mouth—more like an anteater than a toad. In the rainy season, it emerges to breed in temporary pools. The eggs float singly on the surface and quickly hatch into filter-feeding tadpoles.



Parsley frog

Pelodytes punctatus

- ↔ 1–2 in (2.5–5 cm)
- 📍 W. and SW. Europe
- ⊗ Common

Named for the parsleylike green flecks on its skin, this is a primitive burrowing frog—although it lacks the hardened feet of the related spadefoot toads. It also climbs well, its perching ability assisted by a suckerlike underside. During the breeding season, males call out from underwater to attract females, who answer back. Spawning is triggered by rainfall, when each female can produce over 1,000 eggs. These are laid in broad strips

in ponds. The tadpoles grow for several months, often attaining lengths considerably bigger than those of metamorphosed adults. Like most frogs, this species is active at night, spends winter and dry spells hibernating underground, and feeds on insects and other invertebrates.



Holy cross frog

Notaden bennettii

- ↔ 2–3 in (5–7.6 cm)
- 📍 E. Australia
- ⊗ Locally common

This small, round-bodied native of Australia has been named after the distinct, crosslike pattern of warts on its back. Like many of its relatives, this ground-dwelling species spends dry periods underground and emerges during very heavy rains to breed in temporary ponds. The holy cross frog feeds on ants and termites and produces a sticky, defensive secretion when handled.